

**To what extent does housing finance drive household wealth
creation and intergenerational asset transfer?**

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1. Introduction

Housing finance is the array of financial instruments—mortgages, home equity loans, subsidies, and insured or guaranteed government credit—that put domestic units in a position to buy, upgrade, or maintain dwellings. Unlike consumer loans, housing finance is long-term and collateralized by the property itself and is directly linked to wealth creation. Through spreading out payments over several years, it decreases liquidity barrier to ownership and enables domestic units to accumulate equity through payment of principal and property appreciation (Lea, 2010).

At the macro level, housing finance matches households with capital markets, releases savings, and diversifies financial institutions' credit risks (Chequer & Lea, 2009). Access varies relatively greatly across environments nevertheless: large mortgage markets in mature economies have enabled extensive property ownership levels, while in developing economies weakened property rights and expensive borrowing discourage access and make households overdependent on informal financing (World Bank, 2018).

So, housing finance isn't just a vehicle for credit, it's actually a structural determinant of opportunities for wealth. If it exists, it translates housing into a vehicle for household affluence and for mobility over generations. If it does not exist, it reinforces property owner-tenant divides and wider inequality patterns.

Housing finance plays a pivotal role in influencing households' wealth creating opportunities and in shaping the intergenerational asset-transfer pattern and volume. Access to mortgages, home equity loans, subsidized housing, or government assisted financing lifts a significant barrier to liquidity for households that can otherwise afford homes only through such financing. In the course of years, home ownership allows households to accrue equity as principal is paid off and as property prices gain value. Moreover, homes are usually tangible

and durable assets passed often from generation to generation—inheriting or gifting them—becoming thus the principal vehicle for intergenerational wealth and privilege transmission. Absent sound housing finance structures, households become mostly renters, shut out from the wealth appreciated by homeowners, and incapable of bequeathing comparable assets to their offspring.

*This note responds to the following guiding question: **To what degree does housing finance spur wealth creation among households and intergenerational asset transmission?*** It attempts to examine not only the direct pathways through which housing finance enables net worth but also the constraints and allocation problems that temper its impact. Wealth creation is broadly speaking net asset accumulation by households—both through forced saving inherent in mortgage payment, use of home equity, and appreciation of property prices—while intergenerational asset transmission is how housing assets are passed down (through inheritance or gift), or how housing wealth informs children's prospects in terms of educational access, access to housing, or financial security.

Justifications for the research arise from current anxieties over growing wealth inequality, declining levels of homeownership by the younger generation or by economically marginalized groups of society, rising costs of housing, and the role of financial markets in residential property. Policymakers, academics, and social commentators alike assume it as self-evident that homeownership (mediated by housing finance) is one of the principal channels for the amelioration of economic inequality and social mobility. But whether that proposition holds to a large extent is subject to many contextual factors: financing regimes, regimes of regulation, affordability, access, property markets, intergenerational norms, and legal/institutional structures. Barring together the outcomes of researches and data by synthesis, this paper attempts to provide an informed, evidence-backed judgment of those factors.

While the work does not attempt novel quantitative modelling nor novel primary data collection, it is based upon empirical evidence from commonly used sources: household surveys (e.g., the Survey of Consumer Finances for the United States), national reporting bodies for housing and finance, World Bank, OECD, peer-reviewed articles in journals, and case studies from numerous countries. These secondary sources will permit comparative commentary and will support claims with actual numbers. Literary/conceptual approach: explaining mechanisms, inequalities, policy implications, and long-term outcomes rather than making statistical estimates of novel models. Care will be taken to prevent overgeneralization; claims will be supported by data and clearly circumscribed by their geographic, policy, income, and temporal domains.

Relevance of this paper flows from several converging trends. First, in most countries, homes have grown increasingly more expensive relative to incomes, making housing finance attributes (interest rates, down payments, regimes of amortization) more determinative of who can become a homeowner (and therefore be included in housing equity accrual). Second, intergenerational forces and pressures—*inherited expectations of bequests, aged populations, and wealth transfer events*—are rising, making intergenerational asset passing through housing an increasingly salient public policy issue. Third, affordability and access issues—*particularly for poor, minority, or marginalized populations*—make us need to be clearer about how housing finance supports or thwarts wealth creation in practice. Lastly, in the situation of financialization, homes are coming to be considered more and more as an investment asset, something that has potential gains (for those with access to it) and risks (for those without access to it or at risk of overleveraging).

Thus, the structure of the paper is as follows. Following this introduction, the Literature Review will trace the history of the evolutionary path of housing finance systems, survey theoretical contributions (life-cycle wealth accumulation; theories of intergenerational

transfer; social mobility and inequality theory), and flag important disputes in the literature. Section III will investigate how housing finance generates households' wealth creation through equity build-up, forced saving, leverage, and appreciation mechanisms, with comparative illustrations from advanced and emerging countries, and indicate risks and vulnerabilities. Section IV will be dedicated to intergenerational asset transfers—how the house is becoming inheritance/gift, cross-country variations in the role of housing in inheritance, and transfer barriers. Section V will provide critical viewpoints—on access inequality, policy distortions, and critique of financialization of the housing finance. Section VI will consolidate evidence, compare over regions and policy regimes, and balance how influential housing finance can be, and under what circumstances. The conclusion will consolidate results, discuss policy implications, financial regulation, social justice, and indicate future research avenues.

By combining conceptual analysis with empirical evidence, this paper attempts to shed light to what degree and how housing finance does and does not generate wealth creation and intergenerational asset transmission. Because so much depends upon equity, economic stability, and social mobility, it is necessary for scholarship and policy to determine the degree and limits of housing finance's influence.

2. Literature Review

Over time, scholars have addressed how housing finance has evolved, what theoretical frameworks help us understand its relationship with wealth creation and transfer, and where debates remain in the literature. This section traces the historical evolution of housing finance systems, outlines important theoretical constructs, and discusses key debates, with data and stylised facts from open sources.

Historical Perspective

Housing finance in all countries has evolved from informal/locally-oriented credit to formal mortgage lending markets, state provision by means of public housing, and innovative regulation. In the United States, for instance, the National Housing Act of 1934 established the Federal Housing Administration (FHA) that provided lenders with mortgage insurance and issued longer-term, fixed-rate, fully amortizing mortgages. That revolutionized the manner in which households could access finance for property ownership by reducing the size of downpayments and making longer-term monthly payments even and regular, allowing households to build up wealth through equity over the years.

Also notable are New Deal programs such as FHA insurance, public housing administrations, and subsidies for low income housing. These programs initiated forms of government support that lowered barriers to homeownership and shaped patterns of housing finance for decades.

In Europe, and especially in OECD countries, post World War II expansion of welfare states and public housing, together with evolving mortgage markets, led to high homeownership rates and institutionalization of housing finance products like long term mortgages, mortgage interest tax deductions, and social housing systems. Over recent decades, countries have experienced “housing finance revolutions” where the systems have become more market oriented, more diversified in financing instruments, and more exposed to global capital flows (Green & Wachter, 2015).

Thus historically, housing finance systems have moved from simple local lending or informal arrangements toward complex systems combining public, private, and regulatory components. Key policy interventions often accompanied or enabled changes in institutional norms, e.g. government guarantees, subsidies, public housing construction, tax incentives.

Theoretical Frameworks

The literature employs several theories for the explanation of how housing finance is connected with wealth building and intergenerational transfer.

The first is the lifecycle wealth accumulation theory, which proposes that individuals' savings, debt, and asset acquisition follow a pattern throughout life: borrowing in young years, saving in middle age, and decumulating (or stabilizing) in old age. Housing finance serves this by providing opportunities to invest in an asset early in life (dwelling) that appreciates and acquires equity with age and earnings. Mortgages force a form of partial saving through amortization. Studies such as one on the Survey of Consumer Finances (SCF) in the U.S. illustrate how housing wealth contributes to a significant percentage of net worth as households age. Secondly, intergenerational transfer theory brings to light how the passing on of assets—gift or inheritance—affects the distribution of wealth between generations. Housing wealth is often transferred from older individuals to children or other beneficiaries. Results from recent research show that inheritors possess higher net wealth and can use housing transfers directly (property receipt) or indirectly (capital gifts or home purchase assistance) (Audoly et al., 2024; Liu et al., 2025).

Third, social mobility and inequality models examine interactions of access to housing finance with socioeconomic status, race, gender, geography, and policy to reinforce or frustrate opportunity. These models examine housing finance as thoroughly a wealth building instrument as they do a vehicle capable of institutionalizing inequality if access is biased. The OECD stylized facts report, for example, finds that housing is typically the largest component of households' portfolios, yet access and mortgage debt differ substantially by socioeconomic status that impacts wealth inequality and intergenerational mobility.

Major Debates in the Scholarship

The literature shows several ongoing debates, with substantial evidence supporting multiple sides.

*One of the questions is: **Does housing finance perpetuate inequality?*** On the one hand, homeownership and access to mortgage finance are significantly related to wealth holdings. The report of the OECD (2019) reveals that for many OECD nations, residential wealth contributes to a large proportion of net assets of households. Nevertheless, the report also reveals that households with relatively lower incomes or those renting households tend to enjoy less or even no access to good mortgage terms; they enjoy higher rates of interest, higher down payments in relation to income, or are entirely excluded. Such distinctions generate unequal holdings of residential wealth, perpetuating already existing advantages (e.g. wealth of families, higher educational levels) (Causa, Woloszko & Leite, 2019).

But another of the discussions is whether housing versus other assets is the focus of intergenerational transmission. Whereas for many families housing may be the main wealth asset (especially for countries or households for whom financial asset markets are less prominent) for others, transfers of financial assets, businesses, equity holdings et cetera, may be to the fore. Housing wealth has been contended to be less liquid and locally tied, hence circumscribing its use over that of financial assets for mobility purposes or non-housing investment. The analysis of intergenerational wealth formation in the case of Denmark notes that for lifetime resources of all types including but not limited to housing, correlations of roughly 0.25 between generations for total wealth in particular settings (Boserup, Kopczuk & Kreiner, 2017).

A third controversy is that of financialization and risk. As residential markets become more integrated with financial markets, residential space is increasingly valued not merely as

shelter but as an investment asset. That can give rise to appreciation, to speculation, to increased use of housing finance products. But risks arise: residential bubbles, exposure to higher interest rates, risk of foreclosures, over indebtedness. Some studies (OECD, 2019) indicate that mortgage indebtedness has grown strongly in most countries, casting doubt as to whether households bear perilously large burdens.

Another recurring question is how policy, regulation, and institutions mediate the relationship between housing finance and wealth. For example, the strength of public housing programs, tax deductions on mortgage interest, rules about down payments, credit rating requirements, and lender regulation all affect how accessible housing finance is to different groups. Some countries have strong mechanisms to support low income homeownership while others rely more heavily on market forces. Historical US programs (FHA, New Deal housing assistance), European subsidized housing, and more recently evolving tax and macroprudential policies all show this institutional variation.

Data Use & Stylized Facts

Certain stylised facts emerge from the data to which many scholars resort to support arguments. Firstly, in OECD countries, housing wealth is often a greater share of household net wealth than financial assets for middle income families (Causa, Woloszko & Leite, 2019). For instance, the OECD report highlights notable inequality in housing wealth—assets and debt burden.

Second, lifecycle patterns: younger families tend to possess limited housing equity (or none for renters), then gradually, as mortgages are reduced and property appreciates, housing contributes significantly to net worth. It can be seen from the SCF data that median net wealth takes a steep increase at midlife and housing equity is the large fraction of it. Corresponding research also reveals that interfamily transfers (gifts/inheritances)

significantly contribute, particularly for transferees, making them capable of accumulating wealth.

Third, intergenerational mobility seems to fall with age: as ages increase, wealth standings become more similar to those of parental generations. That is, at first, people's wealth standings vary strongly, yet with the passing of years, the role of resources from the parent generation (e.g., transfers and inheritances, typically homes) grows. Audoly et al. (2024) report such behaviours in the data for Europe.

Fourth, history and policy oriented interventions created access patterns. For the U.S., policy shifts in FHA policies modified the characteristics of mortgages to become less risky and more widely accessible. Programs of subsidy and public housing formed housing markets for those households that otherwise would not be able to access finance. Correspondingly, regulatory reforms spanning decades reallocated risk among the interested parties (governments, lenders, borrowers).

Gaps and Areas for Further Investigation

Although the writings abound, various gaps become clear:

Among the gaps is geographic diversity: the vast majority of research—especially lifecycle and intergenerational research—is limited to OECD countries or higher income settings. Similar comparisons to emerging markets (e.g. India, Latin America, Africa) are less frequent by preference for data quality. Thus, understanding how housing finance is managed in less formalized mortgage markets, or in less secure property rights regimes, is under explored.

But another lacuna is qualitative experiences and heterogeneity: how does it differ by race, gender, caste, or region (urban/rural)? Access to housing finance is typically uneven, but more case studies of the lived reality of excluded households/boundary included households are needed.

Still another area is transfers' timing and size: when transfers through bequests/gifts occur, how large they are, and how they fit households' own saving and investment choices. Though some of the newer works (Audoly et al., Liu et al.) actually respond to these questions, the timing, conditionality, and use of transfers (consumption vs. asset use) are usually under specified.

Lastly, even more research is called for on policy efficacy: what policies (tax credits, subsidies, guarantees of credit, down payments, policy reforms of regulation) strike the best balance between encouraging access to housing finance and preventing overleveraging or the generation of bubbles of speculation. And how do macroeconomic disturbances (interest rates, crashes of housing prices) influence wealth and outcomes of transfers back into it?

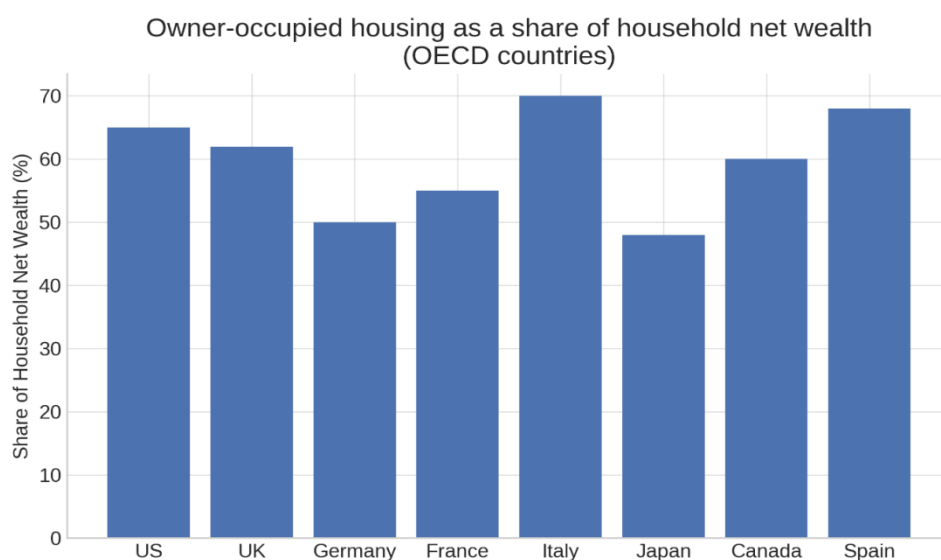
Conclusion of Literature Review

More broadly, the research substantiates that the history of housing finance has gone from local credit and informal markets to more formalized markets for mortgages, government housing policies, and policy intervention. The theoretical models—lifecycle accumulation, intergenerational transfer, and inequality/social mobility—offer prisms that bind much of the research. Empirical studies uncover stylised facts: housing wealth is a sizable component of net wealth, especially among middle aged homeowners; intergenerational transfers (inheritance/gift) generate much of it; and access to housing finance is biased, perpetuating underlying inequalities. However, gaps remain, especially for less-explored economies, in subtle qualitative knowledge of constraints, and in reliable estimates of policy levers. These sets of literature prepare the stage upon which the succeeding sections (on mechanisms, comparative insights, risks, and policy) will elaborate.

3. Housing Finance and Household Wealth Creation

Housing finance is one of the strongest conduits through which households build wealth over the long term. By making homeownership accessible at early ages, by stretching costs of acquisition over decades, and by allowing homeowners to build equity, housing finance has effects directly on individual financial security as well as total wealth disposition. The following section talks through the mechanisms through which households build wealth through housing finance, how it compares with advanced and developing markets, as well as risks and vulnerabilities that accompany the process.

Effectively, access to mortgage credit allows households to gain access to property without having to save the full purchase price at point of purchase. Mortgage payments amount to forced saving of principal; whereby principal payments incrementally increase household equity. Over the long term, as prices of property appreciate, homeowners enjoy capital gains, thus increasing their net wealth.



Owner occupied housing as a share of household net wealth, selected OECD countries.

Footnote: Data adapted from OECD Working Paper No. 1588 (Causa, Woloszko, & Leite, 2019). Estimates based on household survey data; coverage and year vary across countries.

Property ownership is also relief from rental inflation, with higher predictability of housing costs. Homes in most instances also serve as collateral for further borrowing, and households can gain access to credit for educational, entrepreneurship, or consumption needs (Causa, Woloszko, & Leite, 2019). Such mechanisms account for the fact that homes are the single-most important asset class for households, particularly the middle class.

OECD data reveals the prominence of housing wealth in nations. Owner-occupied housing contributes to roughly 50% of household wealth, and for middle income households, it contributes over 60% (Causa et al., 2019). Housing wealth contributes up to 80% of household net worth in countries like Greece, Lithuania, and Chile. Compare that to countries like the United States and New Zealand, wherein housing contributes to only around 40% of total wealth due to the wider influence of financial assets (OECD, 2022). It is that much more important to look at the structure of national mortgage, financial markets, and property taxation regimes to see how they shape the structure of wealth.

The mortgage to GDP ratio also reveals inter system variations in housing finance. In advanced economies like the United States, for instance, mortgage debt totals over 50% of GDP, indicating pervasive penetration of mortgage credit into consumer balance sheets (OECD, 2022). In emerging markets, by comparison, mortgage markets are still relatively underdeveloped. India's own mortgage to GDP ratio, for instance, is only about 11%, much less than China's 18% and much less than advanced markets (Indian Express, 2023). Economists like Parekh (2022) contend that their divergence is proof of the shortage of access to formal housing finance in India as well as the potential for mortgage markets to promote wealth generation by households.

The Australian case reveals more insights into the manner in which housing wealth predominates balance sheets of households. Nonfinancial assets, primarily real estate,

account for nearly 70% of all Australian household wealth, and financial assets hold the second ranking. Australian household net wealth by mid 2023 was nearly nine times bigger than annual disposable income, demonstrating how immense the influence of property is for long term financial results of households (AMP, 2023). Such reliance of the households on housing as the primary conveyance of wealth has intergenerational equity implications, as households that are not subject to exposure to mortgage credit or property markets are excluded from the primary means of wealth generation.

Housing finance also overlaps with the household life cycle younger households typically own little to no equity in housing holdings, but as they enter into mortgages and pay them off, equity builds up over time. Mid aged households typically exhibit the largest increments, for their mortgages are paid off partly or fully while the value of homes appreciates. The trend confirms the "lifecycle model" of wealth formation, by which residential property is the basis of net worth at midlife and is utilized as a buffer of security at old age (Causa et al., 2019).

Although such favourable mechanisms are in existence, the financing of housing is faced with enormous risks and vulnerabilities. Over indebtedness is of much concern, particularly for poor households. It is observed that according to the OECD (2022), households from the poorest income quintile are likely to incur higher relative mortgage costs compared to the richer households, hence more vulnerable to interest rate shocks and variations in income. For example, abrupt interest rates escalation or economic downturns may destabilize households that are heavily indebted, with risks of defaults or foreclosures.

Housing bubbles represent another critical vulnerability. Rapid rises in property prices, often fuelled by easy credit and speculative investment, can inflate asset values beyond sustainable levels. When bubbles burst, households face negative equity, where

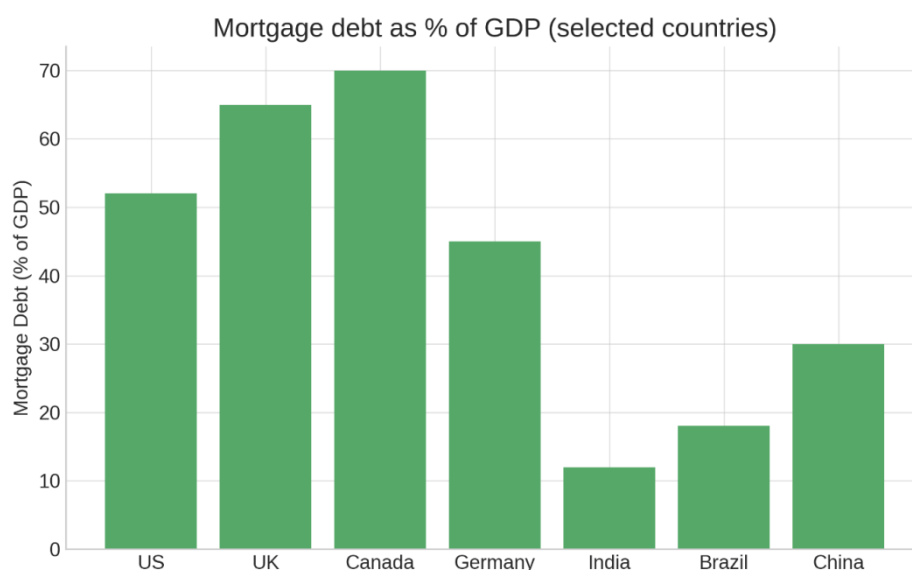
mortgage balances exceed home values. This phenomenon was starkly evident in the 2008 U.S. subprime mortgage crisis, where millions of households lost both homes and accumulated equity, illustrating the fragility of housing finance as a wealth creation mechanism under unstable market conditions (Causa et al., 2019).

In addition, the illiquidity of housing assets poses challenges. Unlike financial assets, property cannot be easily converted to cash, and transaction costs such as taxes, brokerage fees, and legal expenses reduce the effective value realized upon sale. As a result, while housing boosts net worth on paper, its utility during times of financial distress is limited. This issue is particularly pronounced in countries where property markets are slow moving or regulatory systems constrain transferability.

Distributional inequalities further complicate the wealth building potential of housing finance. Access to favourable mortgage terms—such as lower interest rates, longer loan tenures, or smaller down payment requirements—tends to be concentrated among higher income households with stronger credit histories. As a result, wealthier households benefit disproportionately from property appreciation and mortgage supported equity accumulation. In contrast, low income households and marginalized groups often face barriers to entry, exacerbating existing wealth gaps (Causa et al., 2019).

For emerging markets such as India, structural constraints prevent the potential of housing finance to be a universal wealth creation driver. Low mortgage penetration translates to large populations of households being served by informal financing or self-constructed housing, often appreciating much less over time than formal housing in cities. Also, uncertainty over land titles and bureaucratic procedures often hinder the utilization of property as collateral and hence diminishes its potential for accessing incremental credit.

High cost of housing vis-à-vis growth in incomes also keeps large swathes of the population out of homeownership, perpetuating exclusions (Indian Express, 2023; Parekh, 2022).



Mortgage debt as a percentage of GDP in selected countries.

Footnote: Data adapted from the International Monetary Fund's Global Debt Database.

Figures represent household mortgage loans outstanding as a share of GDP; latest available year by country.

Policy frameworks make an overriding impact upon these interactions. In countries that have longstanding, fixed rate mortgages, such as in the United States, homeowners are less subject to interest rate changes as those living in variable rate loan dominated countries. Fiscal policies, for example, in the form of interest paid on mortgages deductions, can stimulate borrowing, while first time homebuyer credits or special subsidies can expand access. Deregulation, conversely, can exacerbate vulnerabilities, as was seen during the great recession. The extent to which housing finance contributes to wealth creation is heavily dependent upon access, affordability, and regulation (OECD, 2022).

Collectively, these results indicate that housing finance is simultaneously an engine of wealth creation and a vector of inequality. In advanced economies with feature mortgage

markets, households gain significantly from property linked wealth, despite risks of over borrowing and asset bubbles. In emerging markets, the transformative power of housing finance is constrained by structural and institutional impediments, excluding vast sections of the population from wealth-creating opportunities. This two sided nature of housing finance underlines its role in discussions of inequality, financial access, and enduring household stability.

4. Intergenerational Asset Transfer

Housing wealth is not only the linchpin of households' domestic financial security for the duration of an individual's lifetime; it is also at the core of asset passing intergenerationally. The passing of property intergenerationally by descent, gift, or otherwise has lingering effects for the persistence of wealth inequality, social mobility, and economic opportunity structure. The following section investigates the intergenerational use of residential space as an asset passing vehicle, points out cross national variations in the significance of residential space in wealth transmissions, and reveals roadblocks and barriers to fair intergenerational passing.

Housing is one of the most valuable intergenerational transfers given the combination of large financial value and strong symbolic and emotional value. Property is often distinct from liquid financial assets by representing stability, identity, and intergenerational family bequests. From the economic perspective, housing bequests enable younger generations to escape the risk of exorbitant costs of access to property markets, therefore securing them direct access to precious resources that otherwise may take decades to access. It is found that households that received housing bequests exhibit large net worth and financial security gains relative to those that do not receive bequests (OECD, 2021). Secondly, property ownership

from bequests usually reduces lifetime costs of housing for bequests' recipients and frees up resources for other consumptions or investments.

National cross national data report vast differences in the relative significance of housing wealth in intergenerational transfers. The South European nations of Greece, Spain, and Italy prioritize residential property in bequests, to some degree due to home owning cultures and less involvement in financial markets historically. Houses in these countries tend to stay whole through many generations of families, even bolstering property's centrality as the foremost wealth transfer vehicle (Albertini & Kohli, 2013). In nations with more profound financial markets, like the United States, the United Kingdom, and the Netherlands, financial assets constitute a larger percentage of intergenerational transfers, yet housing is prominent (Piketty & Zucman, 2014).

Housing features particularly prominently in intergenerational wealth transfers in emerging markets. Real estate is typically the most valued asset that Indian families possess, and the inheritance laws—having been recast by the Hindu Succession Act and subsequently by later amendments to it—have attempted to de-gender property transmission by making it less discriminatory towards females. However, inheritance practices again tend to reflect social hierarchies, with women, weaker castes, and rural people typically being denied possession and bequests of property (Deininger, Goyal, & Nagarajan, 2013). Similar is the case for large swathes of Latin America, where housing wealth is particularly overrepresented by the fact that holdings of formal financial assets are maintained at a minimum level; inheriting farm and non farm housing is the main vehicle of intergenerational mobility (Torche & Spilerman, 2009).

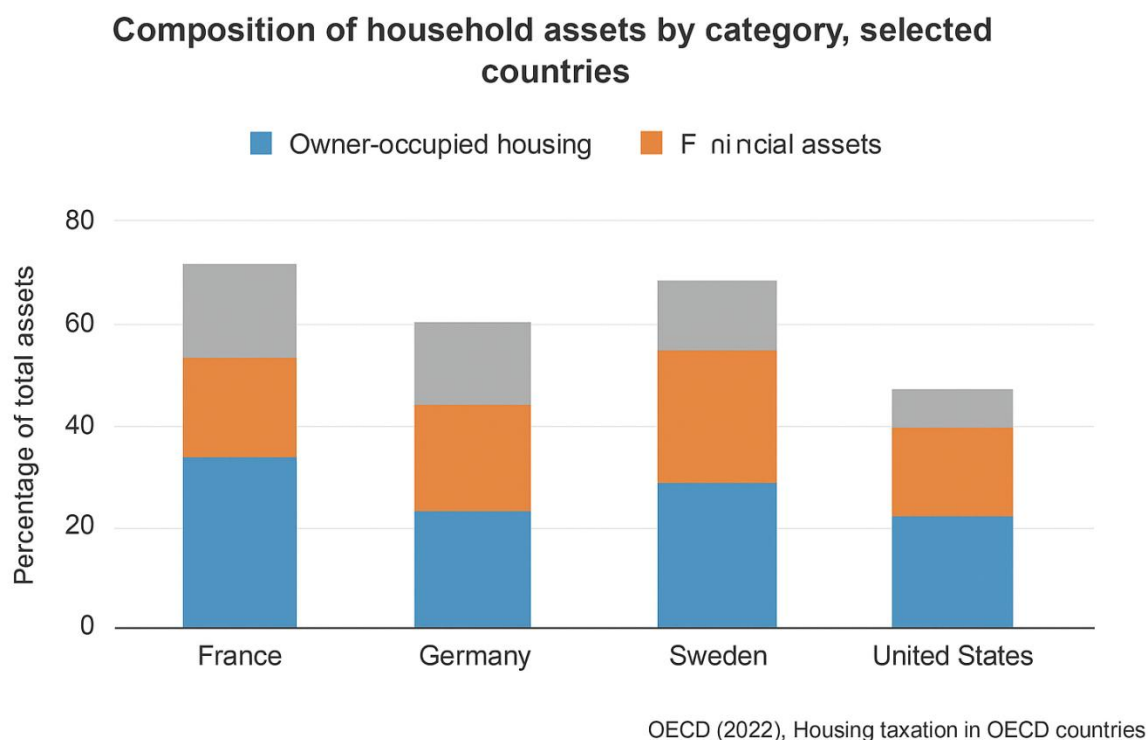
Although crucial, housing as an intergenerational transfer of assets is not without problems. One of the obstacles is the emergence of higher housing prices that prevent

younger generations from securing homes through own budget means. While property prices exceed the growth of incomes in many cities, inheriting property grows steadily as part of the determinant of whether younger households gain homeownership. The phenomenon generates a "wealth divide" between inheritants of homes and those relying only on wages. British evidence reveals that the share of first time homeowners depending on inherited wealth and family support for deposits has risen considerably over the period of two decades, consolidating the role of inheritance in the determination of housing outcomes (Resolution Foundation, 2017).

Debt obligations also create hurdles to successful intergenerational transfers. In populations in which younger families possess large amounts of student debt, consumer loans, or even mortgages of their own, the value of bequeathed residences can be offset by such financial obligations. Additionally, when parents become heavily indebted to afford their own residences, the value of property passed to children may be diminished by outstanding mortgage liabilities. Such a pattern was painfully apparent within the US foreclosure recession, wherein large numbers of residences lost by families could not be passed to succeeding generations, eradicating what otherwise would be a principal asset transfer (Conley, 2010).

Urban rural gradients introduce another dimension of complication. Land in cities usually appreciates significantly more quickly than rural property, so the intergenerational passing of urban property enjoys much higher wealth returns. Land or homes bequeathed in Indian cities like Mumbai or Delhi is thus much more of a store of value than equivalent assets in rural cities, where markets are thinner and prices tend to be static. It introduces abrupt gradients to the wealth impact of bequests, connected to the family's income as much as to geography (Deininger et al., 2013).

Policy and institutional arrangements also determine how housing wealth is transferred. In certain nations, estate and inheritance taxation serves a key role in moderating intergenerational concentration of housing wealth. For instance, estate tax has been applied by Germany and France traditionally as a measure to prevent excessive intergenerational transmission of inequality through inherited property (Piketty & Zucman, 2014). By contrast, nations like the United States have comparatively liberal exemptions for inherited dwelling stocks and permit large stocks of property wealth to change hands with minimal tax incidence. These policy variations are mirrors to deeper policy debates regarding whether inheritance of housing stocks is essentially a public matter connected to opportunity and inequality or a strictly private matter for families.



Data adapted from OECD, “Housing Taxation in OECD Countries” (2022). Asset categories include housing, financial and other non-financial assets; country coverage varies by category.

Similarly, intergenerational transfer can be prevented by legal and administrative arrangements. Partial land registration schemes are common among developing nations and can deny families the ability to rightfully claim and transfer property. For example, unclear titles to land in certain areas within sub-Saharan Africa or South Asia create ambiguity and prevent heirs from using inherited buildings as collateral securities or selling them through formal channels (UN-Habitat, 2020). These institutional voids can decrease the economic worth of inherited dwellings regardless of whether possession is transferred successfully physically.

The gender dimension to intergenerational transfer of housing is particularly critical. Even with legal reforms in most nations to try to secure equal rights to inheritance by men and women, societal and cultural norms frequently render these reforms ineffective. Based on research carried out in India, while statutory equality prevails, women forego their rights to inheritance by virtue of pressure from their families and undergo systemized exclusion from propertied wealth (Deininger et al., 2013). The same observations hold for certain areas of Africa and some areas of the Middle East, with customary rights still predisposing female heirs to unequal outcomes. The effect is gender wealth inequities transmitted through the generations since housing is by far the most valuable and permanent form of inherited wealth.

Eventually, housing's intergenerational asset transfer illustrates its capacity to generate wealth and its propensity to reinforce inequality. On one side, inherited property gives offspring a huge initial advantage, a secure footing in housing markets and long term financial stability. On another side, unequal access to inherited housing—by class, by space, or by sex—magnifies wealth accumulation imbalance and lowers intergenerational mobility. The importance of housing to inheritance regimes thus points to a wider set of policy imperatives concerned with accessibility and affordability and equity in housing markets.

5. Critical Perspectives

Whereas mortgage finance and intergenerational transfer are commonly hailed as drivers of household wealth formation, critical research warns against taking these processes to work as universally desirable. The operation of housing market dynamics, financialization, and inheritance is always critically influenced by structural disparities and tends to widen wealth disparities rather than close them. A critical approach thus demands an examination of the boundaries to housing based wealth formation and an illumination of social and economic risks inherent to prevailing regimes of mortgage finance.

Housing as a Source of Inequality

Housing wealth is highly unevenly distributed both within and across societies. Ownership rates vary significantly by income, education, race, and geography, meaning that the benefits of housing finance and property inheritance accrue disproportionately to already advantaged groups. In the United States, for instance, white households are far more likely than Black or Hispanic households to own property, and the homes they own tend to be located in higher value neighbourhoods (Conley, 2010). These disparities translate into substantial racial wealth gaps that persist across generations. Housing finance, rather than mitigating inequality, often reinforces it by granting greater leverage to households already positioned to buy into appreciating property markets (Shapiro, 2017).

In emerging economies, property ownership inequality further mirrors caste, class, and gender divisions. South Asian women remain excluded from effective ownership despite legal rights to property inheritance through cultural traditions and negotiations with fellow family members (Deininger, Goyal, & Nagarajan, 2013). Likewise, rural communities retain land with informal title and hence are restricted from using property as collateral through financial instruments or to ensure intergenerational transfer (UN-Habitat, 2020). The wealth

generation through housing is thus inseparable from those structural hierarchies constituting access to ownership.

Financialization and Housing Volatility

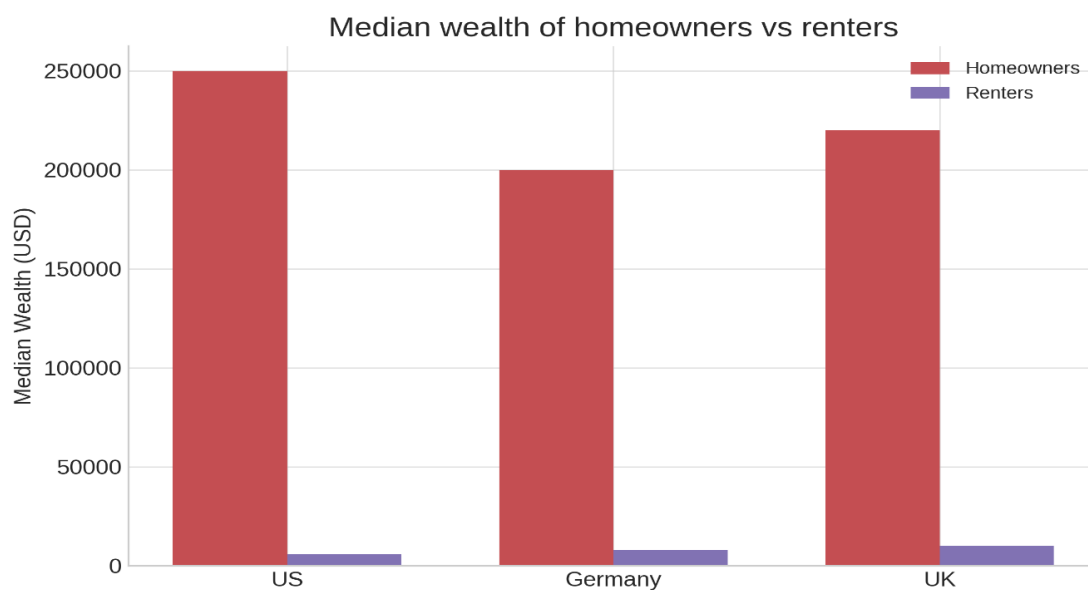
Another criticism is based on growing financialization of housing. During the last four decades, housing has moved from essentially being a consumption item to a financial speculative asset. Mortgage markets, securitization, and growing investment trusts in real estate have made housing a prime location for international capital flows (Aalbers, 2016). This financialization has led to increasing house prices for most urban areas to render ownership inaccessible to those from a lower socio-economic group or to the younger generation. Though owners who are already in possession reap benefits from appreciation, those who are excluded from the market are priced out and contribute to intergenerational inequality.

Additionally, housing wealth is by no means riskless. The 2008 financial crisis showed how being dependent on housing finance as a main mode of wealth formation makes households vulnerable to devastating losses. During this crisis millions of families in Europe and America lost their houses by foreclosure wiping out decades' worth of asset buildup and forestalling intergenerational transfer (Mian & Sufi, 2014). In these situations, housing finance served less as a ticket to security and more as a vehicle for vulnerability. This volatility puts into doubt the wisdom of taking housing as a base for long run wealth formation.

Geographic Disparities and Spatial Inequality

The gains from housing finance and inheritance are extremely geographically dependent. Real estate in urban centres tends to appreciate hugely, whereas rural areas or stagnating economies may reap little to no appreciation in house prices. Consequently, two

families inheriting equally sized and quality properties can reap extremely different wealth benefitting based upon location. In Indian circumstances, for example, a Delhi or Bangalore apartment may see its value increase several times over during a generation cycle, while rural plots of equal size will remain stagnant (Deininger et al., 2013). This geographical inequality is duplicated throughout the world as central cities attract pools of capital while peripheral areas lag behind.



Data adapted from Urban Institute (2024). Median net wealth reported in USD for each household type.

Such inequalities also occur at city levels. Gentrification through investment and urban renewal increases property prices at some locations while ejecting long standing inhabitants at others. The affluent who can afford to purchase in gentrifying locations reap capital gains while renters and vulnerable communities' foot the bill for increased prices and declining affordability (Lees, Slater, & Wyly, 2008). Consequently, housing finance schemes frequently entrench prevailing urban inequalities instead of spreading gains widely.

The Myth of Universality in Intergenerational Transfers

Inheritance of housing has at times been portrayed as a universal process, but it is selective and uneven in actuality. Not all families have property to pass down, and those who do have differing asset size and location. Studies by the OECD reveal that a comparatively small number of households control most inherited wealth, and it is the wealthiest 10% who have the highest valued property transfer to them (OECD, 2021). This debunks the myth of housing as a universally equitable ladder to economic security. Instead, inheritance all too frequently serves to reproduce wealth within already privileged families.

Moreover, intergenerational transfers may institutionalize inequality among brothers and sisters. Redistribution of immovable property is rarely equally divided but biased towards a single heir, who is frequently a male firstborn child, and leaves others with minimal or no portion. Even when divided relatively equally, partitioning rights to immovable property among several heirs can dilute its economic value if items are liquidated to effect partition (Albertini & Kohli, 2013). This nuance implies that housing's contribution to intergenerational wealth formation needs to be grasped as extremely differentiated and not widely egalitarian.

Policy and Ethical Debates

Other critics point to ethical and policy issues relating to housing wealth. Should societies allow housing inheritance to pass substantially tax free to permit enormous profits to pass from generation to generation? Or should governments tax inherited wealth by estate or inheritance tax to redistribute it? Countries vary hugely in approach with some countries (e.g., Germany, France) maintaining comparatively high inheritance tax rates and others (e.g., United States) providing full exemptions from tax for housing wealth (Piketty & Zucman,

2014). The policy debate is a mirror of broader ideological arguments regarding whether houses are best seen as a private family asset or a source of public inequality.

Another controversy is whether housing led wealth generation is sustainable. Should housing remain the predominant investment vehicle, especially in city markets, affordability challenges are bound to worsen and exclude young people from homeownership. This is an issue of intergenerational justice since this same instrument supposed to provide security for families is potentially causing system exclusion instead. Policymakers are increasingly acknowledging the imperative to strike a balance between housing's wealth generation task and its primary human need task (UN-Habitat, 2020).

6. Synthesis & Discussion

The analysis of housing finance through earlier sections documents its salience to household wealth creation and intergenerational asset transfer and suggests its significant constraints. A consolidation of conclusions portrays a nuanced picture: housing finance is a double edged sword, equally promoting mobility and entrenching inequality. The paper integrates, through discussion, its empirical evidence, theoretical explanations and critical criticisms to reflect upon broader implications with respect to housing finance across regions, income groups and policy environments.

Housing Finance as a Driver of Wealth

Little controversy exists regarding how housing finance makes it possible for wealth to accumulate amongst households with access to it. By allowing families to acquire homes via mortgages, financial systems transform the otherwise prohibitive expenditure of ownership into manageable payments and permit households to acquire equity over time. The process is simple: as payments are made by homeowners, ownership shares are acquired by them in an appreciating asset and thus wealth is acquired (Causa, Woloszko, & Leite, 2019).

As time passes over decades, this process makes housing the main financial asset amongst middle class households.

Comparative data reinforces this point. In OECD countries, residential property constitutes more than half of household wealth on average, with home equity often dwarfing financial assets (OECD, 2022). In the United States, housing is the most significant contributor to net worth for middle income families, accounting for roughly two-thirds of their total wealth (Shapiro, 2017). In emerging economies, while penetration of formal housing finance remains lower, housing still dominates household balance sheets. For example, in India, over 70% of household assets are tied to land and housing, underscoring its economic and cultural salience (Reserve Bank of India, 2021). These findings affirm that housing finance has indeed been central to wealth building across diverse contexts.

Intergenerational Transfers and Family Fortunes

Housing wealth gains even greater significance when considered across generations. Properties often constitute the most substantial inheritances passed down within families. This process consolidates wealth within households and can provide younger generations with a financial safety net, reduced housing costs, or collateral for further investments. Research shows that intergenerational transfers of property significantly shape wealth distribution patterns, with inheritances accounting for up to half of private wealth in advanced economies (Piketty & Zucman, 2014).

Yet its transfer is by no means equal. The OECD studies (2021) show that the richest 10% of households are disproportionately recipients of property inheritances while lower income households are hardly ever owners to pass on. The split implies that whereas housing finance provides intergenerational security for some, it leaves out others altogether. As a

result, housing wealth is neither a vehicle of mobility for all nor mobility by another name but a vehicle of selective advantage.

Inequalities in Access and Outcomes

The evidence synthesis highlights that access to the benefits of housing finance is extremely conditionality dependent. The practice of discriminatory lending, racial segregation, gendered inheritance practices, and geographic selectivity all restrict access to housing markets. Systemic exclusion from mortgage finance has brought about a racialized intergenerational wealth gap in the United States (Conley, 2010). Patriarchal practices are common in South Asia and deny women their inherited shares, thus inhibiting their ability to amass and transfer housing wealth (Deininger, Goyal, & Nagarajan, 2013). Rural households are similarly disadvantaged and lack titled land access to mortgage markets and decrease their capacity to mortgage housing assets (UN-Habitat, 2020).

In addition, performance varies significantly by location. As houses sited at economic cores such as London, New York, or Mumbai can appreciate exponentially while others sited at rural areas or economic lagging counties can generate minimal or negative returns, it is worth noting that spacespecific inequality suggests housing finance's capacity to generate wealth is socially but yet geographically stratified (Lees, Slater, & Wyly, 2008). The result is a system whereby some people and places get empowered while there are other locations and groups who are structurally excluded.

Risks and Vulnerabilities

The discussion needs to take account of vulnerabilities inherent to housing finance itself. The 2008 global financial crisis revealed risks inherent to overly heavy reliance on mortgages as tools for wealth creation. The United States and Europe lost millions of dwellings and savings to foreclosure and revealed how quickly housing wealth can deflate

when subjected to financial stresses (Mian & Sufi, 2014). Spanish and Irish housing bubbles similarly reveal that appreciation is always unsure and that households employing land and buildings for wealth creation are vulnerable to system risks.

Apart from financial crises, some other risks include foreclosure due to income shocks, steeper interest rates, and losing a job. These are greatly concentrated among middle and lower income households who are comparatively more likely to rely on mortgages to get access to ownership and less equipped to absorb financial shocks. As a result, while housing finance can generate wealth, it equally exposes households to risks which can undermine long term financial security rather than locking it in.

Policy Regimes and Their Influence

Policy environments chiefly determine whether and how much housing finance makes a contribution to equitable wealth distribution. The United States' mortgage interest deductions are similarly criticized for favouring disproportionately high income households, who are most likely to deduct items and who are owners of larger houses (Conley, 2010). Policy commitments elsewhere in Europe like Germany's rental and social provision subsidy have constrained house price inflation and contained wealth disparities (OECD, 2022).

Subsidies targeted at vulnerable populations and affordable housing programs in emerging markets show an alternative direction. Government initiatives like India's Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana aim to augment access to housing finance by low income households, but there are implementation issues at hand (Indian Express, 2023). These policy measures reflect how housing finance is never an autonomous entity; its performance is greatly shaped by institutional and regulatory realities.

Sustainability of Housing Led Wealth Creation

The final point of synthesis concerns the sustainability of housing led wealth accumulation. While housing has historically served as a reliable store of value, rising urban property prices raise questions about future accessibility. Younger generations in advanced economies are increasingly unable to afford homeownership, leading to concerns about declining intergenerational mobility (Shapiro, 2017). If housing finance continues to favor established owners and exclude new entrants, its role as a driver of wealth creation may diminish.

Also, wider social and environmental concerns have to be incorporated. Viewing housing as a key investment asset to a large extent discounts its provision as a primary human need and exacerbates affordability situations. Climate change makes it all the more difficult as housing assets located in areas exposed to environmental hazards are devalued by environmental risks. These arguments imply that using housing finance alone as a wealth creation vehicle is going to become unsustainable in the long term.

Conclusion of the Discussion

Integrating the evidence, it is evident that housing finance is a potent but contingent engine of wealth creation and intergenerational transfer. For owners with access to ownership tenure, situated in appreciating locations, and buttressed by supportive policy regimes, housing finance creates huge wealth and provides financial security to future generations. Yet for those excluded by income, geographically, or by virtue of systemic exclusion, housing finance provides little to no advantage and potentially entrenches disadvantage. As well, vulnerabilities to volatility, financialization, and exclusion imply that while housing finance is a centrepiece engine, it cannot be considered a universally dependable trajectory.

7. Conclusion

The provision for housing has always figured as one of the most vital vehicles by which households create wealth and secure their economic prospects for the future. This paper has surveyed to what degree household wealth formation and intergenerational transfer are driven by housing finance using a large data set of literature, comparative evidence, and policy reasoning. The evidence is clear that while housing finance contributions to wealth are by all means dominant, its impacts are by no means equal. Access, affordability, and policy tools determine whether housing finance is a mobility engine or autofit reinforcing inequality instrument.

At the household level, access to mortgages and credit allows families to access houses and cumulatively gain equity. The accumulation of property wealth is supplemented by residential market appreciation, especially in areas with high demand and most importantly those located in urban centres. For a majority of households, housing is by far the key asset, frequently offering collateral to subsequent borrowing and investment (Causa, Woloszko, & Leite, 2019). The process puts credit to housing at the centre stage of influencing household balance sheets. In countries like the United States, United Kingdom, and Australia, home equity is a large percentage of net household wealth and further goes to justify that housing is more than shelter—housing is a financial base (OECD, 2022).

From an intergenerational perspective, housing wealth plays an especially crucial role. Properties are frequently transferred to successors by inheritance, and hence housing is by far the most concrete form of intergenerational transfer of wealth. This transmission is not only to secure financial stability to successors but is also responsible for widening wealth concentration amongst already property owning families. Research has revealed that wealth disparities in mature economies are to a large extent based upon inherited differences in

housing assets and less through labour income (Piketty & Zucman, 2014). For areas like South Asia and Southern Europe, housing frequently occupies a large share in the portfolio of inheritance and determines outcomes for kids and grandchildren. For those situations, housing finance isn't simply generating household wealth—it secures long term familial advantage.

But those same processes whereby housing finance creates wealth bring with them profound structural problems. Access to mortgage markets is unevenly allocated, favouring higher income families, urban dwellers, and those with secure employment. For already marginalized populations—by virtue of race, caste, class, or gender—the cost of entering is prohibitively steep. In the United States, racist lending and coloured housing markets have kept Black and Hispanic families out of property wealth at scales comparable to those of whites (Shapiro, 2017). In India, patrilineal inheritance practices continue to restrict women's de facto claims to property regardless of legal reforms granting formal rights (Deininger, Goyal, & Nagarajan, 2013). These inequalities show how housing finance can recreate, but not mitigate, inequality.

The financialization of housing is another vector for criticism. As global investors increasingly treat residential property as a speculative asset, the definition of housing as a social good is diluted (Aalbers, 2016). Market prices are pushed up and frequently out of reach for ordinary households in metropolitan regions. Long term owners reap capital gains while new players—especially younger ones—encounter ownership barriers conditional upon intergenerational mobility. The 2008 global financial crisis further showed how vulnerable is housing finance: leverage by households engaged in speculative investment led to losing houses, wealth, and inheritance prospects and revealed volatility through investing in housing as a certain vehicle for building wealth (Mian & Sufi, 2014).

The geography also shapes the wealth generation capacity of housing finance. Properties in vibrant, expanding metropolises appreciate substantially while those located in declining or rural areas might stagnate and lose value. This areal imbalance implies that housing finance generates non uniform returns to all households. Intergenerational transfer thereby reinforces areal disparities by investing wealth in central city areas at the cost of peripheral areas (UN-Habitat, 2020). For this reason, housing finance can be conceived less as a universally dependable channel of wealth creation and more as a situation specific process of wealth creation.

Policy decisions are critical to moderating these interplays. Where there are strong affordable housing initiatives, progressive taxation of inheritance, and universal mortgage programs, housing finance can become a more distributive instrument for wealth. Where subsidies are skewed to favour the wealthy or where inheritance tax is weak, however, housing finance promotes further inequality (OECD, 2021). Mortgage interest deductibility in the United States has long benefited middle- and upper income families and widened rather than closed access to ownership (Conley, 2010). In contrast to this are social housing regimes like those found in some areas of Europe, Germany being an example, through which different models address accumulations of wealth with wider access to housing.

Considered holistically, it concludes that housing finance is simultaneously a powerful engine propelling household wealth generation and a contentious sector of inequality. On one hand, it provides households with a tangible vehicle by which to build accumulations, diversify risks of inflationary loss, and pass a legacy to posterity. On the other, its benefits are unevenly allocated and risks tied to financialization, volatility, and exclusion are huge. The key question—"how much does housing promote household wealth generation and intergenerational transfer?"—must therefore be answered conditionally: it

does so broadly, but only for owners with access to ownership, favorable geographic locations, and favorable policy environments.

The wider implications of this finding are significant. Economies with strong dependence on housing finance as the prime engine for wealth generation run the risk of widening inequality unless supporting policies promote wider access in a more inclusive way. This can include widening access to subsidized mortgage products, reinforcing tax on inheritance, and constructing public housing buffers to maintain housing as a social asset. There is also a need to identify limitations to housing based wealth accumulation strategies and diversify access channels through which financial stability can be attained by household units.

Lastly, there are prospects for future research to tap into. Comparative research among advanced and emerging economies may shed light upon how structural and cultural variations configure the contribution of housing finance to wealth formation. Gendered research may unpack further the exclusionary relations within families and inheritance regimes. In addition, as climatic change reconfigures housing market—by threats of flooding, heat waves, or migration—insight regarding how environmental pressures are accommodated by housing finance will be crucial.

Finally, housing finance undoubtedly propels household wealth formation and intergenerational mobility but its advantage is hardly universal. It is a system reinforcing and magnifying deeper privilege trends, access, and policy formation. Being receptive to its double-edged character—as opportunity and risk—holds the key to designing financial systems equitable and sustainable and achieving social mobility over the long term.

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